

FOOD SAFETY

Adults

Q

What pH level is generally considered safe to prevent the growth of *Clostridium botulinum* in home-canned foods?

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ANSWER

4.6 or below

FUN FACT

Foods with pH 4.6 or below are called high-acid foods and do not support botulism growth.

Source: SP 50-1001 PH values

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Why must herbs and vegetables stored in oil be refrigerated or frozen when made at home?

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ANSWER

To prevent the growth of *Clostridium botulinum* in the oxygen-free oil environment

FUN FACT

Commercial garlic-in-oil mixtures are acidified to safely store at room temperature.

Source: SP 50-701 Herbs and vegetables in oil

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What is a critical food safety practice to avoid cross-contamination during home food preservation?

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ANSWER

Wash knives and cutting boards with hot soapy water after contact with raw meat

FUN FACT

Separating raw and ready-to-eat foods prevents bacterial spread.

Source: PNW 250 You can prevent food borne illness

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What should you do if you find a home-canned jar with a bulging lid and spurting liquid when opened?

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ANSWER

**Discard the contents
immediately without tasting**

FUN FACT

Bulging lids often indicate dangerous bacterial growth such as botulism.

Source: SP 50-490 Botulism

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For low-acid canned vegetables, what processing method is recommended to ensure safety?

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ANSWER

Pressure canning at specified times and pressures

FUN FACT

Low-acid foods need pressure canning because spores survive boiling temperatures.

Source: SP 50-714 Science of food preservation

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Why is it important to follow tested home canning recipes exactly without altering ingredients or proportions?

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ANSWER

Changes can affect acidity or heat penetration, risking unsafe food

FUN FACT

Modifying recipes can unexpectedly enable bacterial growth.

Source: SP 50-714 Science of food preservation

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What is the recommended headspace for home-canned high-acid foods like fruits or pickles?

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ANSWER

1/4 inch to 1/2 inch

FUN FACT

Proper headspace allows air to escape and creates a good vacuum seal.

Source: SP 50-1001 PH values

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What precaution should you take when home canning tomatoes in a boiling water bath?

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ANSWER

Add bottled lemon juice or citric acid to increase acidity

FUN FACT

Adding acid is a safety step to prevent botulism in tomato canning.

Source: SP 50-490 Botulism

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How long should home-canned vegetables or meats be boiled before tasting as a safety measure?

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ANSWER

10 minutes plus 1 additional minute per 1,000 feet elevation

FUN FACT

Boiling helps destroy botulinum toxin if present before tasting.

Source: SP 50-490 Botulism

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What is the 'danger zone' of temperatures where harmful bacteria grow most rapidly during food preservation?

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ANSWER

40°F to 140°F

FUN FACT

Keeping foods out of this temperature range prevents bacterial growth.

Source: PNW 250 You can prevent food borne illness

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What is the safe minimum internal temperature to cook whole poultry including turkey to ensure food safety?

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ANSWER

165°F

FUN FACT

Use a food thermometer to be sure poultry is safely cooked.

Source: SP 50-1000 Turkey basics

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How soon should eggs or egg dishes be refrigerated after cooking or preparation?

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ANSWER

Within 3 hours

FUN FACT

Refrigerate eggs promptly to reduce Salmonella risk.

Source: PNW 250 You can prevent food borne illness

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What characteristic of mold on home-canned food always indicates that it is unsafe to eat?

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ANSWER

Visible mold growth on the surface

FUN FACT

Never taste or reuse foods with mold to avoid toxins.

Source: SP 50-934 USDA molds on food

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Why is refrigeration necessary for homemade flavored oils like pesto or garlic-in-oil mixtures if not acidified?

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ANSWER

To prevent anaerobic growth of *C. botulinum* bacteria

FUN FACT

Low acidity plus oil creates perfect conditions for botulism without refrigeration.

Source: SP 50-701 Herbs and vegetables in oil

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What is the effect of altitude on home canning processing times?

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ANSWER

Processing times must be increased at higher altitudes

FUN FACT

Water boils at lower temperature with altitude, needing longer cooking.

Source: SP 50-490 Botulism

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Which symptom is a warning sign to discard home-canned food immediately without tasting?

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ANSWER

Food spurting liquid when opening the jar

FUN FACT

Spurting liquid indicates gas build-up from unsafe bacterial growth.

Source: SP 50-490 Botulism

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Why should leftovers be reheated to 165°F before eating?

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ANSWER

To kill bacteria that may have grown during storage

FUN FACT

Use a thermometer to check reheated food safety.

Source: PNW 250 You can prevent food borne illness

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What is an important step before handling food to reduce chances of contamination?

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ANSWER

Washing hands with soap and warm running water

FUN FACT

Handwashing is the simplest way to prevent foodborne illness.

Source: PNW 250 You can prevent food borne illness

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Why are tomatoes considered borderline between high-acid and low-acid foods in canning safety?

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ANSWER

Because some varieties have pH near 4.6 which may allow botulism if not acidified

FUN FACT

Adding lemon juice increases acidity for safer boiling water canning.

Source: SP 50-490 Botulism

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What is the recommended storage method for homemade flavored oils if you cannot use them within four days?

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ANSWER

Freeze them in airtight containers

FUN FACT

Freezing preserves the flavor and safety of homemade oils long term.

Source: SP 50-701 Herbs and vegetables in oil